to him: a hermit called Mukand Brahmachari undertook a penance in Prayag ‘so that he might be born a powerful Kshatriya king and exterminate Islam from India’.[45] Some error in his prayer – or a play of the gods – produced a mixed result: the determined hermit was reborn, yes, but as a Muslim himself: the emperor Akbar.

Like the Hindu reborn a Muslim, Akbar was acquiring new lives as he lived, in the customs, the legends and cultures of his people. The emperor who had once proclaimed the victory of Islam in Chittorgarh was hailed as Hindupati, ‘Lord of the Hindus’, by a contemporary poet called Holrai.[46] Siddhi Chandra, a Jain monk in Akbar’s court, wrote, ‘There is not a single art, not a single branch of knowledge, not a single act of boldness and strength which is not attempted by young Akbar’ – and compared him to the son of Kaushalya, that is, to Rama.[47] Amrit Rai, writing his ballad-biography of Man Singh, the *Mancharita*, in the early 1580s, describes Akbar as a ‘cagattā cakkavai’, a Chagatai Chakravartin, a wonderful amalgamation of Mongol and Hindu king. Akbar had ‘rescued dharma, virtue, and generosity from drowning, as Varaha rescued the earth’, he goes on. In the poet’s free-flowing imagination, however, Akbar is not only an avatar of Vishnu, like Varaha – or Rama and Krishna as others in his court declared their emperor to be. In fact, as with Chagatai and Chakravartin, Amrit Rai manages a poetic union between Akbar and Vishnu himself, such that ‘The goddess Lakshmi shares her time between Vishnu’s embrace / and nestling at Akbar’s breast.’[48]

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It might appear from the preceding pages that Akbar was binding his people to him with equal parts justice, generosity and miracles, while terrifying and pauperizing his nobility into obedience. Akbar’s understanding and deployment of his own authority was far more complex, however. Yes, his amirs were greatly more subservient than the cantankerous warlords who had blithely deserted Akbar’s father on the banks of the Ganga in Kannauj, or risen in rebellion against Akbar himself, but it was not their deference alone that the emperor desired – it was also their devotion.

The year 1582, or 990 in the Hijri calendar, was significant in more ways than one: politically, of course, in that it ended the dreams of Mirza